time and Washington's growing discomfort with excessive Indian presence in Afghanistan. Nonetheless, naval bases in Goa and Mumbai for the US fleets to assemble, and 'stage-through' facilities at air force bases for the US to employ long-range bombers, were sought. The meeting ended with India refusing to put boots on the ground, but allowing over flight, landing, and refueling facilities for US air mission and port calls by naval ships as well as intelligence sharing, and helping with the investigation of the 9/11 incidents.[113]

The split between the partisans and conciliators is reflected in Indian deliberations over Blair's proposal. Though the details of this meeting remain classified, media reports and interviews with senior Indian policymakers indicate a divided house. According to a *Times of India* report, at least two members of the CCS made a 'vigorous pitch' for accepting US demands and advocated joining the war on terror unconditionally. Admiral Sushil Kumar opposed the idea, saying that the US and its allies did not, at least until then, enjoy a UN mandate on Afghanistan (which was offered on 20 December 2001), and that India had not declared war on Afghanistan. Vajpayee concurred with the conciliators' counter-argument and refused to cater to all of Blair's requests.[114] Though the identity of individuals advocating military alignment remains secret, Advani's aversion of the Taliban and Jaswant Singh's open support for military cooperation are well known. India had agreed to 'facilitate' military action in April 2001, and had been providing military and logistical support to the UF since the mid-1990s. In this context, the US demand for military support fit the partisan's vision of Afghanistan perfectly. However, India's final decision to not send troops signified that it was keen on keeping all options open instead of taking sides and developing hostilities with Afghans.

The dilemma of whether or not to ally with the US became acute on 13 December 2001, when five gunmen allegedly associated with the JeM and the LeT barged into the parliament and killed fourteen people in a shooting spree. India was shocked. In a subsequent parliamentary address, Jaswant Singh stated that the ghastly attack 'on 13th December 2001 has shocked the entire nation. The terrorist assault on the very bastion of our democracy was clearly aimed at wiping out the country's top political leadership'.[115] Between May 1990 and April 2000, Indian security forces had seized 33,763 weapons of various caliber, three million